

The state of the web

We take a look at some of the changes implemented by Google and Facebook with their services and also look at other developments in the web world

The state of the web hasn't changed much. Once again, the usual suspects such as Facebook, Google, Microsoft and Twitter have made a few tweaks, launched a few services and otherwise, carried out some maintenance work. There were some interesting developments you should be aware about.

Google round-up

Google has announced the deepening of the Google+ integration for YouTube, allowing users to link their channels with a Google+ page. The company is pushing out the prompt to all its users and one can opt in right now by tweaking YouTube account settings. Efforts to integrate the two have been on since earlier this year, when the company started asking users to employ their real names while using YouTube. This was followed by Google urging users to hook their Google+ profiles with their YouTube channel/profiles.

Another new Google+ integration is with Android apps. Now users can share links to Android apps with their circles and friends within that circle get an option to install the app directly from the stream itself. To use this feature, you paste the URL of the particular app as your status. Google+ will automatically embed an Install/Buy button beside it. Once the app is visible in the status, you can replace the link with your status message.

The search giant is also working to improve its Google Drive service, with a new update making it easier for users to access the Drive cloud-

storage service from the Chrome browser, by rolling out relevant apps of Drive to the Chrome Web Store. Users can now also more easily find, organize and view their files on Drive. It also brings support for Google Earth files. Other updates include auto-completion of names, creation of new folders while organising files, folder drag-and-drop abilities in Chrome and files in the trash appearing during search.

If you've sent out mails from Gmail over the past month, you may have noticed an updated compose feature. On clicking on 'Compose Mail', a New Message box will open just like a chat window would. So say you are looking at mails in your inbox and you want to compose a mail, Gmail won't open a separate compose mail page. Instead, you'll be able to see the contents of your inbox while typing out your mail in the New Message box. You can even insert images inline. Another Gmail update, meanwhile, focuses on making it easier to find mail. Now users can look for email by size, exact match and more flexible date options within Gmail.

The search page layout has some changes as well, with its navigational tools shifted from the upper-left of the page to the top of the page.

Google has also updated its Maps service and Google Earth with high resolution aerial and satellite imagery for a number of new cities and has added 45-degree imagery for scores of locales across the globe. According to the company's official blog, so far 164 cities

and 108 countries/regions have the high resolution images, including Washington and Austria. The new 45-degree imagery has been applied to 60 cities – 40 of which are located in the U.S.



Google Earth Maps update

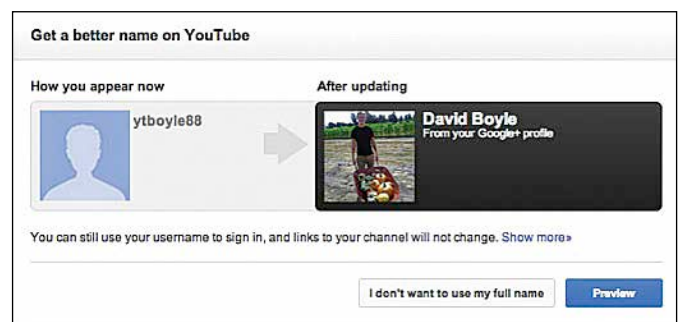
Facebook round-up

The social networking giant is testing two new features for the News Feed section – Upcoming Events and Recently Released Albums. Reports claim that some users have already begun seeing the two new features in their News Feed. Upcoming Events is quite similar to the “upcoming concerts” module, which some users began to see in October. The Recently Released Albums, as the name suggests, highlights the recently launched album by an artist, which a user has listened to on Spotify or any other music service linked to the social network.

Facebook is reportedly also testing a new format for Timeline, which will put all posts in a single column on the left, while the activity modules and friends, places, apps and other sections will be placed on the right. The new Timeline layout will help Facebook address several complaints from users regarding the display of the posts in the new profile. Timelines for dates, which allows users to jump to a particular month or year, will show up in the top-right of the page.

Back in August, Facebook introduced a new layout for its messages in an attempt to make them read more like email conversations. The new layout now appears to have begun rolling out to more users. The new design features a side-by-side layout that shows your most recent message on the left and the whole conversation on the right. There are options to add multiple photos and emoticons. Users can now also search by typing a sender's name or keyword in the main messages view. To further ease-of-use, there are also new keyboard shortcuts.

Facebook has also rolled out a redesign of 'Friendship



Google allows users to link Google+ profile with YouTube channel